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The BJP has given tickets to seven MPs, including Rajya Sabha member Kirodi Lal Meena. A party source says an internal survey had indicated that 10 of the 25 sitting MPs could lose the election if they were fielded again. This is perhaps what prompted the party to ask some of them to prove their worth in an assembly segment in their Lok Sabha seat. "This is a new-era party. Prove that you have what it takes or risk being discarded," says a leader privy to the party's strategy and inner discussions. It has fielded two former Union ministers and two former state ministers in tough seats, ones where the party has not fared well in the past decade.

Indeed, the first list consists mostly of such seats. The saffron party has not won the past three elections in 19 seats, and lost in another 21 in 2018. Ticket selection seems to reflect this. Twenty-nine candidates who contested these seats in 2018 have been denied tickets this times. Ten tickets have gone to outsiders who had contested then, including eight independents and two former Bahujan Samaj Party candidates. There are 17 fresh faces, while 11 are party rebels who contested in 2018. Age, too, seems to have been a consideration—except for Meena, all the other candidates are under 70, with a good number in the 40-60 age group. The caste mix suggests that 25 candidates are from the 'general category' while 16 come from the reserved classes.

The first major revolt came in what is widely believed to be a safe seat, Vidyadhar Nagar, a planned colony designed by architect B.V. Doshi in 1980 from where former royal Diya Kumari, the current MP from Rajsamand, has been asked to contest. She replaces sitting MLA Narpat Singh Rajvi, son-in-law of the late Bhairon Singh Shekhawat, a former CM and also vice-president of India. Rajvi, who has represented the constituency since 2008, reacted strongly, questioning the BJP patronising the Jaipur royalty to "end Shekhawat's legacy". He calmed down only after a meeting with Arun Singh, general secretary in charge of Rajasthan. Diya herself appeared quite contrite, saying, "Rajvi is like my elder brother...I have just obeyed the party's wishes."

Rajvi is a recent convert to the Raje cause. At least a dozen strong contenders claim they have been denied tickets for being close to Raje, though the party is claiming that her consent was taken for at least half the seats. In Jhotwara, Rajpal Singh Shekhawat, a known Raje supporter and four-time MLA who lost in 2018 has been replaced by MP and former Union minister Rajyavardhan Rathore. Rathore and Diya are both Rajputs and replace contenders from the community. Even so, sources say Shekhawat and other local heavyweights such as Ashu Singh Surpura could make things difficult for the former Olympic champ.

THE BJP HIGH COMMAND HAS FORMED A PANEL TO PACIFY THE REBELS, BUT EVEN THAT DOES NOT HAVE LEADERS OF STATURE

The other big names facing opposition are Alwar MP Baba Balak Nath (contesting from Tijara), Vijay Singh Bainsla, son of the late Kirori Singh Bainsla who spearheaded the Gujjar agitation (from Deoli-Uniara), and Ajmer MP Bhagirath Choudhary, who is contesting from Kishangarh. Choudhary faced a social media onslaught from Vikas Choudhary, the 2018 nominee in this constituency, whose hashtag 'I worked hard with honesty' was trending for days. Some other dissidents, too, used the hashtag, which became an embarrassment for the BJP.

Party analysts agree that the BJP high command may be risking a little too much to ring in the changes they want. They have even formed a committee to pacify the rebels, but again it does not have leaders of stature and relies on those with an RSS background. Even relatively safe seats like Sanchore have become a problem, with local leaders protesting against the candidate Devji Patel. Almost all the BJP mandal leaders there have quit in protest. Leader of the Opposition Rajendra Rathore, though, is unperturbed. "We will win 70 per cent of these 41 seats," says the seven-time MLA.

The party is trying to act firm against the rebels. In Sanchore, it immediately replaced the six mandal chiefs who resigned. These were the BJP's weakest seats, and it has got time to curtail the protests, but the move will fail if the Congress comes out with better candidates. A similar strategy to replace established leaders in the next list may see bigger revolts that could dent the party's prospects. ■